A Judge Pauses the Giant Arch

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A judge paused a giant arch in Washington, D.C., just after it won approval. Just before midnight on Thursday, District Court Judge Tanya Chutkan blocked building for 14 days at the request of Washington, D.C., and Virginia.

The 250-foot arch would stand in Memorial Circle, between the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington National Cemetery. Her 33-page **opinion** said local governments would likely be harmed by traffic problems.

Less than two hours earlier, the National Capital Planning Commission had approved the arch 8 to 4. It heard nearly eight hours of talks, and about 131 people signed up to speak, most against it.

Critics said it would block a view, make busy **airspace** less safe, and disrespect service members buried nearby. They also asked if it is legal and what it would cost, which is still unknown.

Supporters, including two Republican members of Congress, called it a **tribute** to the nation and to those who served, saying Congress approved the idea in 1925, when it approved two tall columns for the same place that were never built. **Lawsuits** from Vietnam War veterans, an **architectural** historian, and D.C. and Virginia are still in court, so for now the arch is on hold.

Word Treasure

airspace -- The airspace is the sky above a place where planes fly.

tribute -- A tribute is something made to honor and remember a person or group.

architectural -- Architectural means having to do with the design of buildings.

Lawsuits -- A lawsuit is a case in court where someone asks a judge to decide a disagreement.

opinion -- In court, an opinion is a judge's written explanation of a decision.

Background you need

A big arch is a tall, curved structure that can be built as a monument to honor something important.

This arch would stand in Memorial Circle, a place between the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington National Cemetery, where service members are buried nearby.

The idea is meant as a tribute to the nation and to those who served, and a similar plan for two tall columns in the same place was approved long ago but never built.

Break it down

WHO: District Court Judge Tanya Chutkan, Washington, D.C., and Virginia, the National Capital Planning Commission, critics, and supporters including two Republican members of Congress.

WHAT: A judge blocked building of a 250-foot arch for 14 days, less than two hours after the commission had approved it 8 to 4.

WHERE: Memorial Circle in Washington, D.C., between the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington National Cemetery.

WHY: The judge's 33-page opinion said local governments would likely be harmed by traffic problems.

Why it matters

It matters because the arch would change a place many families visit to remember service members, and the pause gives the courts time to decide whether it should be built there.

Test what you remember

1. How tall would the arch be?

- (A) 33 feet
- (B) 250 feet
- (C) 131 feet
- (D) 14 feet

2. Who blocked building the arch for 14 days?

- (A) Two Republican members of Congress
- (B) An architectural historian
- (C) District Court Judge Tanya Chutkan
- (D) The National Capital Planning Commission

3. Where would the arch stand?

- (A) In Memorial Circle, between the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington National Cemetery
- (B) Next to the White House
- (C) In Arlington National Cemetery
- (D) In Virginia

4. How did the National Capital Planning Commission vote on the arch?

- (A) It did not vote
- (B) It approved it 8 to 4
- (C) It voted 14 to 2 in favor
- (D) It voted 4 to 8 against it

5. About how many people signed up to speak at the commission hearing?

- (A) About 33 people
- (B) About 131 people
- (C) About 250 people
- (D) About 8 people

6. What did supporters call the arch?

- (A) A danger to busy airspace
- (B) A tribute to the nation and to those who served
- (C) A project with an unknown cost
- (D) A block to the view

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: A 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Critics: Critics said the arch would block a view, make busy airspace less safe, and disrespect service members buried nearby, and they asked if it is legal and what it would cost, which is still unknown.

2. Supporters: Supporters, including two Republican members of Congress, called the arch a tribute to the nation and to those who served, saying Congress approved the idea in 1925, when it approved two tall columns for the same place that were never built.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):